

# Injured hawk offers life lessons for students

Omni Montessori students, parent come to bird's rescue

It wasn't planned, but Susie Gaudioso's sixth-grade class at Omni Montessori School launched into a broad unit encompassing biology, veterinary medicine, ornithology, humanitarianism, fundraising and marketing - on the first day of school.



**Angel Trimble**

Omni Montessori's main campus, nestled along Blakeney Heath Road not far from Ballan-

## Want to help?

The Carolina Raptor Center is a nonprofit organization that receives about 1,000 injured or orphaned raptors each year and is dedicated to the conservation of birds of prey through education, research and rehabilitation. Details: [www.carolinaraptorcenter.org/home](http://www.carolinaraptorcenter.org/home).

tyne, is a schoolyard habitat registered with the National Federation of Wildlife.

The lesson began when a brown blur went streaking past the class' windows, catching the teacher's eye and momentarily distracting students. A pair of binoculars was brought out, and the

See **Injured hawk**, 9SN



Elizabeth Cady, identified as No. 18239, stands on a perch provided by the Carolina Raptor Center.

CAROLINA RAPTOR CENTER



Charleston  
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10/19/14



COURTESY OF SUSIE GAUDIOSO

This photo of Elizabeth Cady was taken shortly after the bird was rescued.

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[ from ISN ]

students took turns watching as a man cautiously approached the trees across the open area outside their classroom.

That man was Kevin Crimmins, who was there with his wife to pick up their daughter from the half-day primary program.

"We were looking around the playground when a strange sound drew our attention to the trees, and there was this bird kind of hanging upside down from a branch, flapping its wings," said Crimmins.

The bird appeared stuck, but Crimmins knew from experience that precautions needed to be taken. He'd worked on a capital campaign with a raptor center in Charleston, S.C., and had the opportunity to participate in a few rescues.

Crimmins went to Gaudioso's classroom to ask for something to cover the bird: He received a curtain and gloves, and was able to get close enough to cover the bird.

That's when he realized the bird's wing was impaled on a branch.

With a school staff member's assistance, Crimmins cut the branch from the tree and lay the injured bird on the ground.

Keeping its head covered with the curtain, Crimmins worked to prune away as much of the branch as possible.

He said the bird seemed unnaturally calm, and he began to worry, but it suddenly jumped and unsuccessfully tried to flap its wings.

While Crimmins worked to rescue the bird, the students watched, took photos, cleaned out a small dog carrier to contain the bird and asked what else they could do.

A volunteer from the Carolina Raptor Center took the injured bird to the center in Huntersville.

The bird was identified as an adult Cooper's hawk and is believed to be female, based on its size and weight. According to the Cornell Lab of Ornithology's website [www.AllAboutBirds.org](http://www.AllAboutBirds.org), Cooper's hawks range from 14 to 20 inches long with a wingspan of 29 to 37 inches, and females are usually

larger than males. They feed mainly on other birds and are among the world's most skilled fliers.

Dr. Dave Scott went to work on the bird's injury, which he described in layman's terms as a massive wound in the right armpit.

Gaudioso's students called Scott to get updates on the bird and ask questions about hawks.

It was Women's Equality Day when the students found out the hawk was female, so they named her Elizabeth Cady, in honor of Elizabeth Cady Stanton, an early leader in the push for women's equality.

At the Raptor Center, Elizabeth Cady is known as No. 18239. Scott said it is very rare that they give patients names. "They are wild animals, and we try not to treat them like pets or get too attached, as our goal is always to release them," he said.

The class researched hawks and other birds of prey and regularly checked the Raptor Center's online log to track Elizabeth Cady's progress.

They could tell from the

comments she was doing well, but they also noticed just how much it cost to care for her.

The students made colorful signs to post around the school and used Friday pizza sales to collect donations. Their efforts brought in nearly \$250, but Elizabeth Cady's expenses total more than \$1,100.

The students are brainstorming fundraising ideas, from advertisements in the school newsletter to charging admission for a release party.

After 52 days of treatment and rehabilitation, Elizabeth Cady/No. 18239 is nearly ready for release.

"She is doing really well," Scott said. "She has healed quickly and is in a big flight cage and actively flying every day."

When she's ready, they'll schedule her release on the Omni Montessori campus with the students cheering her on.

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